Unsafe After Dark: What 12,820 Flood-Affected Villages in Pakistan Report About Women's Sanitation, Childbirth and Protection from Abuse, and What They Are Never Asked

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Introduction

After floods, humanitarian agencies assess thousands of villages to decide where aid goes. These assessments shape what is seen: needs that are not asked about are rarely funded. Topics surrounded by shame, such as open defecation, menstruation, childbirth and sexual exploitation by aid providers, are the easiest to leave out. This study examines what Pakistan's largest public village-level flood assessment records about women's safety and dignity, how women's situation compares with men's in the same villages, and which sensitive topics the questionnaire omits, to inform SDGs 5, 3 and 10.

Methodology

The study analysed public village-level data from the International Organization for Migration's Displacement Tracking Matrix: 6,292 villages in Balochistan and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (August 2024) and 6,528 in Punjab after the 2025 floods (September–October 2025), home to about 16 million people. In each village a group of key informants answered. The share of villages reporting each problem was calculated, answers about women and men were compared within villages, and both questionnaires (327 and 286 fields) were searched for sensitive topics. Results describe villages, not individual women; informants' sex is unpublished.

Findings, Outcomes and Implications

Women defecate in the open in 36% of villages. Where they do, 69% of villages report this is unsafe for women after dark, against 15% where women use latrines. Women usually give birth at home in 13% of villages; elsewhere the median walk to a birth facility is two hours. Only one village in five has any channel to report misconduct by aid workers, including sexual exploitation. Neither questionnaire asks about menstruation, violence, child marriage, pregnancy, disability or transgender people. Assessments must ask women directly, and ask about what is taboo.

SDGs: 5, 3, 10. Data: IOM Displacement Tracking Matrix, Community Needs Identification (Flood Response) Rounds 6 and 7, via the Humanitarian Data Exchange.